“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 16

A Brief Description of the Youthful Pastimes

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 I worship Caitanya Prabhu. The river of His nectarean mercy floods the whole universe, and yet, like every river, it always flows downward — to the lowly.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 Glory to Caitanya in His youth! When He entered household life, Lakṣmī herself served Him in visible form; and then Sarasvatī, the goddess of speech, worshipped Him as well, taking His victory over the conqueror of all directions as her occasion.[2]

4 Here, in outline, are the pastimes of His youth. He began to teach students of His own.[3]

5 He taught constantly, with hundreds of students around Him, and all who heard His explanations were amazed.

6 In every branch of learning every paṇḍita met defeat at His hands, yet His manner was so courteous that no one was hurt.

7 With His students He played all kinds of pranks, and they sported merrily in the waters of the Gaṅgā.

8 After some time the Lord went to East Bengal, and wherever He went He had the people take up the chanting of the holy name.[4]

9 Seeing the power of His learning, hundreds of students came in wonder to study with Him.

10 In that land lived a brāhmaṇa named Tapana Miśra, who could not settle what the goal of life is and how it is reached.[5]

11 Many scriptures and many opinions had confused his mind, and he could not decide which goal is highest and which means is best.[6]

12 In a dream a brāhmaṇa said to him, “Listen, Tapana. Go to Nimāi Paṇḍita.

13 He will settle for you the goal and the means. He is the Lord Himself — have no doubt of it.”

14 After this dream Miśra came to the Lord’s feet and told Him all that he had dreamt.

15 Pleased with him, the Lord explained the goal and the means, and instructed him: “Chant the holy name.”[7]

16 He wished to live with the Lord in Navadvīpa, but the Lord told him, “Go to Vārāṇasī.

17 There we shall meet again.” Receiving this order, Miśra went to Kāśī.

18 The Lord's pastimes are endless and beyond my understanding. Why did He send Miśra away from His company to Kāśī?

19 In this way the Lord did good to all the people of East Bengal: giving them the holy name He made them devotees, and teaching them He made them paṇḍitas.[8]

20 While the Lord enjoyed these many pastimes in East Bengal, here in Navadvīpa Lakṣmī grieved in separation from Him.

21 The snake of separation from the Lord bit Lakṣmī, and by its poison she passed from this world.[9]

22 Dwelling in every heart, the Lord knew of it; and, aware of Śacī's grief, He returned home.

23 He came home with much wealth and many followers, and by speaking of the truth He freed Śacī from her grief.[10]

24 Again He gathered His students and delighted in the play of learning; by the power of His knowledge He conquered everyone and showed a proud spirit.

25 Then came His marriage to Viṣṇupriyā Ṭhākurāṇī, and after that the Lord's victory over the *digvijayī*, the conqueror of all directions.[11]

26 Vṛndāvana dāsa has described all this at length, but he did not set out clearly the merits and faults of the *digvijayī*'s verse.

27 Bowing to him, I shall tell of that analysis; hearing it, the *digvijayī* cursed himself.

28 One moonlit night the Lord sat with His students on the bank of the Gaṅgā, discussing points of learning.

29 Just then the *digvijayī* came there and, after offering his prayers to the Gaṅgā, met the Lord.

30 The Lord received him with respect and gave him a seat, but the *digvijayī* spoke with disdain in his heart:

31 "You teach grammar, and Your name is Nimāi Paṇḍita. People praise Your skill in the science that children learn.[12]

32 Of the grammars, I know, You teach the *Kalāpa*, and I have heard of Your students' debates on its tricky points."[13]

33 The Lord said, "Yes, I teach grammar — or so I like to think. But My students do not understand, and I cannot explain it to them.

34 "How far above Me you are! You are expert in every śāstra and in poetry, while I am only a child, a new student.

35 "I should like to hear some of your poetry. Be kind enough, if you will, to describe the Gaṅgā."

36 Hearing this, the brāhmaṇa proudly began, and within one *ghaṭī* he described the Gaṅgā in a hundred verses.[14]

37 When He had heard them, the Lord honoured him highly: "There is no other poet in the world like you!

38 "Who has the power to understand your verses? You alone know their meaning well — you, or Sarasvatī.

39 “If you would explain the meaning of one verse yourself, everyone here would be delighted to hear it.”

40 The *digvijayī* asked which verse he should explain, and the Lord recited one of the hundred.

41 “This greatness of the Gaṅgā ever shines beyond compare, for she is blessed by her birth from the lotus feet of Śrī Viṣṇu. Like a second Śrī Lakṣmī, she receives the worship of gods and men; and upon the head of Bhavānī’s husband she reigns, endowed with wondrous qualities.”[15]

42 When the Lord said, “Explain this verse,” the *digvijayī* asked Him in astonishment:

43 “I recited those verses like a storm wind. How could You learn one of them by heart?”

44 The Lord said, “By the boon of a deity you are the best of poets; and by the boon of a deity another may become a *śruti-dhara*, one who holds all that he hears.”

45 Well pleased, the brāhmaṇa explained the verse. Then the Lord said, “Tell Me, what are the merits and faults of this verse?”

46 The brāhmaṇa said, “No fault appears in it. Its merits are the ornament of simile and some alliteration.”[16]

47 The Lord said, “May I say something, if you will not be angry? Tell Me what faults there are in this verse of yours.

48 “Your words, full of genius, please even the gods; yet if they are examined well, both merits and faults come to light.[17]

49 “So let us examine the verse carefully.” The poet replied, “The verse You have recited is the very essence of the Vedas.

50 “You are only a grammarian; You have not studied poetics. What can You know of the essence of this poetry?”[18]

51 The Lord said, “That is just why I ask you. Examine its merits and faults and explain them to Me.

52 “I have not studied poetics, but I have heard it taught, and so I see many faults and merits in this verse.”

53 “Come, then,” said the poet, “tell me — what merits and faults?” The Lord replied, “I shall tell you; listen, and do not be angry.

54 “In this verse there are five faults and five ornaments. I shall name them in order; listen, and judge for yourself.

55 “In two places the predicate is badly placed, and there are three more faults: a contradictory sense, a broken order, and a return to a finished sentence.[19]

56 “In this verse the main predicate is ‘the greatness of the Gaṅgā’, while the subject, expressed by the word *idam*, ‘this’, comes after it.[20]

57 “You stated the predicate first and the subject afterwards, and so the meaning of the verse has suffered.[21]

58 ‘One should not state the predicate without first stating the subject; for nothing that has not found its footing can stand anywhere.’ (Ekādaśī-tattva, 13)[22]

59 “In *dvitīya-śrī-lakṣmī*, ‘a second Śrī Lakṣmī’, the predicate is ‘being second’; but in the compound it has become secondary, and the meaning of the word is lost.[23]

60 “The word *dvitīya* is the predicate, but it has fallen into a compound, and so the point — that the Gaṅgā is equal to Lakṣmī — is destroyed.

61 “This fault is called *avimṛṣṭa-vidheyāṁśa*. Now listen attentively to another.

62 “With great satisfaction you used the words *bhavānī-bhartuḥ*, ‘of Bhavānī’s husband’. But this is a grave fault, called *viruddha-mati-kṛt*: such words suggest a contradictory sense.

63 “The word *Bhavānī* means the wife of Mahādeva. When you name her husband, it sounds as if she had another husband.

64 “‘The husband of Śiva’s wife’ sounds absurd; by the rules of the śāstra, words that suggest a contradictory sense are faulty.

65 “If one says, ‘Give the gift into the hand of the brāhmaṇa’s wife’s husband,’ the very words make one think of a second husband.

66 “The sentence is complete with the verb *vibhavati*, ‘reigns’, and then you add another epithet, *adbhuta-guṇā*, ‘endowed with wondrous qualities’. This return to a finished sentence is the fault called *punar-ātta*.

67 “In three lines I see matchless alliteration, but in one line there is none; this fault is called *bhagna-krama*.[24]

68 “Though the verse has five ornaments, these five faults have ruined it.

69 “Even if a verse had ten ornaments, a single fault would bring them all to nothing.

70 “It is like a beautiful body adorned with jewels: one spot of white leprosy disgraces it.

71 ‘As a body, though beautiful and adorned, is made unsightly by a single spot of white leprosy, so poetry rich in rasa and ornaments loses all its charm if it has a fault.’ (Bharata Muni)[25]

72 “Now hear the analysis of the five ornaments: two are verbal ornaments and three are ornaments of meaning.

73 “The first verbal ornament is the alliteration in three lines; the second is the seeming repetition (*punar-uktavad-ābhāsa*) in the words *śrī-lakṣmī*.

74 “In the first line there is a row of five *ta*s, and in the third, five *ra*s.

75 “In the fourth line four *bha*s appear; this is the verbal ornament of alliteration.

76 “The words *śrī* and *lakṣmī* name one and the same thing; it seems almost a repetition, yet it is not one.

77 “For if *śrī-lakṣmī* is taken as ‘Lakṣmī endowed with beauty (*śrī*)’, the two words differ in meaning; and this seeming repetition is a kind of verbal ornament.

78 “The words *lakṣmīr iva*, ‘like Lakṣmī’, are an ornament of meaning: a simile. There is another ornament of meaning, called *virodhābhāsa*, apparent contradiction.

79 “Everyone knows that lotuses are born in the Gaṅgā; but to say that the Gaṅgā is born in a lotus is a flat contradiction.

80 “Yet here the Gaṅgā has her origin in the lotus feet of Viṣṇu, and this ornament of contradiction is wonderful indeed.

81 “The Gaṅgā appears by the inconceivable potency of the Lord, so there is no contradiction here — only the semblance of one.

82 ‘The lotus is born in water; nowhere is water born from a lotus. But with the slayer of Mura it is the reverse: from His lotus feet the great river was born.’[26]

83 “The greatness of the Gaṅgā is what is to be proved, and the proof of it is her birth from the feet of Viṣṇu; this is the ornament called *anumāna*, inference.[27]

84 “These are the five obvious faults and the five ornaments; examined more finely, they would be countless.

85 “Your genius and your poetic gift come by the grace of a deity; but into poetry composed without reflection faults are bound to creep.[28]

86 “With reflection, poetry becomes flawless, and when it is adorned with ornaments, its meaning sparkles.”

87 Hearing the Lord’s words, the *digvijayī* was astonished. No word came from his mouth; his genius was struck dumb.

88 He wanted to say something, but no answer would come, and in his perplexity he thought:

89 “A schoolboy has robbed me of my wits! Surely Sarasvatī is angry with me.

90 “No human being could give such an explanation. Sarasvatī herself must be speaking through Nimāi’s mouth.”

91 Thinking thus, he said, “Listen, Nimāi Paṇḍita: Your explanation has astonished me.

92 “You have not studied poetics, and You have no training in the śāstras. How could You bring out all these meanings?”

93 Hearing this, Mahāprabhu, who dearly loved a jest, read his heart and answered playfully:

94 “Whether My analysis of the śāstras is good or bad, I Myself do not know. I only speak the words that Sarasvatī makes Me speak.”

95 Hearing this, the *digvijayī* concluded, “The goddess has defeated me through a child.

96 “Today, with japa and meditation, I shall lay this before her: through a child she has humiliated me so!”

97 In truth, it was Sarasvatī who had him compose a faulty verse, and when it was examined she clouded his intelligence.

98 Then all the students began to laugh, but the Lord checked them and said to the poet:

99 “You are a great paṇḍita, the crest-jewel of poets, for such poetry flows from your lips.

100 “Your poetry is like the stream of the Gaṅgā’s waters; nowhere do I see another poet like you.

101 “Even in the poetry of Bhavabhūti, Jayadeva and Kālidāsa faults appear.[29]

102 “I count such analysis of faults and merits a small thing; what I praise is their power to compose poetry.

103 “Do not take My childish pranks to heart. I am not even fit to be your student.

104 “Go to your lodging today; tomorrow we shall meet again, and I shall hear you expound the śāstras.”

105 So the two went home, and that night the poet worshipped Sarasvatī.

106 In the night Sarasvatī instructed him, and he came to know that Nimāi was the Lord Himself.

107 In the morning he came and took shelter at the Lord’s feet, and the Lord showed him mercy and cut his bonds.[30]

108 The *digvijayī* was fortunate, and his life bore fruit: through his learning he attained the feet of Mahāprabhu.

109 Vṛndāvana dāsa has described all these pastimes; what little I have done here is to set out certain points more fully.

110 The pastimes of Caitanya Gosāñi are a stream of nectar: whoever hears them finds every sense fully satisfied.

111 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. A play on words: *nīca-gā* means both “flowing downward” and “going to the lowly”. *Anubhāṣya*: the Lord’s mercy is always turned towards the humble and destitute, who have neither wealth nor greatness. ↩
2. *Anubhāṣya*: Lakṣmī, having taken a body, served the Lord when He entered household life; Sarasvatī, the goddess of speech, honoured Him when He defeated the *digvijayī* — the scholar Keśava Kāśmīrī, “conqueror of the directions”. Heading in the edition: “Gaurahari, worshipped by Lakṣmī and Sarasvatī.” ↩
3. *Anubhāṣya*: *kaiśora*, youth, is the period from the eleventh year of life to the fifteenth. ↩
4. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* (introduction to the chapter): the Lord went to East Bengal to gather funds; there He held learned discussions and spread the chanting of the holy name. ↩
5. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *sādhya* is what is attained; *sādhana* is the means by which it is attained. ↩
6. *Anubhāṣya*: one who seeks the highest good should not study many books or live by expounding scripture (*Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* 7.13.8); the flowery words of scriptures that nourish karma and knowledge lead the inexperienced away from pure devotion (11.21.30, 36). Through Tapana Miśra’s doubts the Lord teaches those who follow many scriptures and many teachers. Later, in Vārāṇasī, Tapana Miśra heard the Lord’s answers to Śrī Sanātana’s questions on the goal and the means, and his doubts were resolved. ↩
7. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the Lord said that neither knowledge of the non-dual Brahman nor the pleasures of heaven is the goal of the soul; its only goal is love for Kṛṣṇa. Karma and knowledge are not the means to it; the only means is pure devotion that takes shelter of the name of Kṛṣṇa. ↩
8. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the Lord gave the people of Bengal the name of Kṛṣṇa — “Hare Kṛṣṇa Hare Kṛṣṇa Kṛṣṇa Kṛṣṇa Hare Hare / Hare Rāma Hare Rāma Rāma Rāma Hare Hare” — and so made them devotees, and by teaching them the śāstras He made many of them scholars. ↩
9. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the pain of separation from the Lord took the form of a snake and bit Lakṣmī, and she went to “the other world” — her own abode,

Vaikuṇṭha, the highest of all. ↩

10. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: there is a reading “with the net of truth” (*tattva-jāle*): “Who is whose husband, who is whose son, who is whose wife?” — casting such a net of true knowledge, the Lord relieved Śacī’s grief. ↩
11. Heading in the edition: “Marriage to Śrī Viṣṇupriyā, daughter of the royal paṇḍita Sanātana, and the defeat of Keśava Kāśmīrī.” *Anubhāṣya*: the *digvijayī* was the paṇḍita Keśava of Kashmir. He travelled through India conquering scholars by his genius and was defeated in Navadvīpa by Śrī Gaurasundara. Having learned the truth about Mahāprabhu, he entered the Nimbārka sampradāya for the sake of devotion and wrote the *Kaustubha-prabhā*, a gloss on Śrīnivāsācārya’s *Vedānta-kaustubha*, the commentary on Nimbārka’s *Pārijāta-bhāṣya*. ↩
12. *Anubhāṣya*: “the children’s science” is grammar, for before studying any śāstra one customarily learns grammar in order to know the language. ↩
13. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the Lord teaches the *Kalāpa* grammar, and His students hold discussions on its *phāṅki* — its intricate and puzzling questions. ↩
14. A *ghaṭī* (*ghaṭikā*) is a measure of time of twenty-four minutes. ↩
15. Heading in the edition: “Keśava Kāśmīrī’s verse on the greatness of the Gaṅgā.” *Anubhāṣya*: *subhagā* — possessed of a splendid fortune, since she was born from the Lord’s lotus feet; *dvitīya-śrī-lakṣmīr iva* — like a second Kamalā (Lakṣmī), full of beauty; *bhavānī-bhartuḥ* — of the husband of Bhavānī, that is, of Śiva; therefore the Gaṅgā is endowed with wondrous qualities. ↩
16. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: simile (*upamā*) is a poetic ornament (*alaṅkāra*); alliteration (*anuprāsa*) is the verbal art shown by setting many *bha*s close together in the last line. ↩
17. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *pratibhā*, genius, is the power of mind that arranges words in ever new ways; in this verse you have shown it and pleased even the gods, but on careful examination both merits and faults appear. ↩
18. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: a grammarian is versed only in the elementary science and cannot judge poetics (*alaṅkāra-śāstra*) and other śāstras. ↩
19. The names of the faults (*doṣa*) in the original: *avimṛṣṭa-vidheyāṁśa*, “the predicate not duly considered”, that is, what is asserted about the subject is badly placed (vv. 56–61); *viruddha-mati-kṛt*, “that which suggests a contradictory sense” (vv. 62–65); *punar-ātta*, “taken up again”: a return to a sentence already completed by its verb (v. 66); *bhagna-krama*, “broken order” (v. 67). ↩

20. *Vidheya*, the predicate, is what is asserted about a thing, the new matter for the hearer; *anuvāda*, the subject, is the thing itself, already known. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: in the verse the main predicate is the greatness of the Gaṅgā and the subject is the word *idam*; to write “the greatness of the Gaṅgā” first and *idam* after it is against the rule. ↩
21. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: if the subject is not stated first, the meaning is impaired. ↩
22. Heading in the edition: “Thus a maxim cited in the *Ekādaśī-tattva*.” The same verse is quoted in Ādi 2.74 (there *anuktvā tu*, here *anuktvaiva*, with the same meaning). ↩
23. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the purpose of these words is to show that the Gaṅgā is equal to Lakṣmī; but “second”, the predicate, was put into a compound (*samāsa*), became secondary, and that meaning perished. ↩
24. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the first, third and fourth lines alliterate on *ta*, *ra* and *bha*; the second has no alliteration. ↩
25. Heading in the edition: “Thus say the words of Bharata Muni.” *Anubhāṣya*: rasa means *śṛṅgāra* and the others; ornaments are alliteration, simile and the like; *durbhaga* means bereft of beauty (*śrī*), dimmed. ↩
26. Headings in the edition: “The inconceivable potency of Kṛṣṇa” and “A verse spoken by the Lord, Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Himself.” *Anubhāṣya*: in Kṛṣṇa cause and effect are reversed — from His lotus feet flowed the great river, the Gaṅgā. ↩
27. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the words about her birth from Viṣṇu’s feet prove what was to be proved — the greatness of the Gaṅgā; this is the ornament of inference (*anumāna*). ↩
28. *Anubhāṣya*: if poetry is not examined, its faults are not easily seen. ↩
29. *Anubhāṣya*: Bhavabhūti, or Śrīkaṇṭha, wrote the Sanskrit dramas *Mālatī-mādhava*, *Uttara-rāma-carita*, *Vīra-carita* and others; he lived in the reign of King Bhoja and was the son of Nīlakaṇṭha and grandson of Bhaṭṭa Gopāla, a brāhmaṇa of Padmanagara. Kālidāsa was the great poet, one of the “nine jewels” at the court of Vikramāditya, author of the *Raghuvaṁśa*, *Kumāra-sambhava*, *Abhijñāna-śakuntala*, *Megha-dūta* and some thirty or forty other poems, dramas and works. On Jayadeva, see Ādi 13.42. ↩
30. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: his bondage was the bondage of māyā in the form of pride in his learning. ↩